

FreePrints Photobooks — First-Time Purchase Teardown

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Method: one session on the iOS app, from install through checkout. A single 32-page softcover book was built and taken to the payment screen. Observations cover the new-customer acquisition flow only; post-purchase email, account, and fulfillment touchpoints were outside the scope of this session.

The core issue. The opening offer promises a totally free photo book with free shipping. Checkout charged \$4.68. Between those two screens sits a page-count decision that the app largely makes on the user's behalf and never prices. Acquisition is doing its job — the leak is in the stretch between the offer and the purchase, and it is the same stretch that has to earn the second order.

P0 Page overage is not priced anywhere before checkout

OBSERVED

The new-customer offer states “TOTALLY FREE — Free Photo Book, Free Shipping” with no mention of a page allowance. The finished book ran 32 pages. At checkout, the 12 pages beyond the 20-page allowance were billed at \$0.39 each, for \$4.68. No per-page price appeared during photo selection or editing, and the rate is not published on the App Store or Google Play listings — it is discoverable only by incurring it.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the one charge in the flow that contradicts the promise used to acquire the customer. A user who feels surprised at the payment screen is unlikely to return for the second book, which is where the free-first model has to make its money.

HYPOTHESIS

Surfacing running page count and incremental cost during selection reduces new-customer cart abandonment without meaningfully reducing average order value — users who want 32 pages will still want 32 pages once the price is visible.

METRIC

Cart-to-purchase conversion, new-customer cohort. Secondary: first-order refund rate and support contacts referencing unexpected charges.

RECOMMENDATION

A persistent counter through selection and editing: “20 of 20 pages included” → “32 pages · 12 extra × \$0.39 = \$4.68.” One always-visible line, no interstitial or confirmation dialog — the goal is to remove the surprise, not add a step.

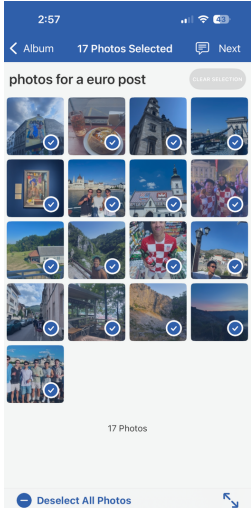


Photo selection. Page count and its cost are absent from this screen and every screen after it.

P1 The editor runs two competing interaction models at once

OBSERVED

Pages can be edited by tapping directly on a page, and separately through a bottom navigation bar (Background, Arrange, Add Pg, Delete Pg). Entering a tool and backing out gives no indication of current state or position in the flow. The first-run instructional overlay is dismiss-only and cannot be recalled; persistent hint text at top-left partially compensates and is the stronger of the two patterns.

HYPOTHESIS

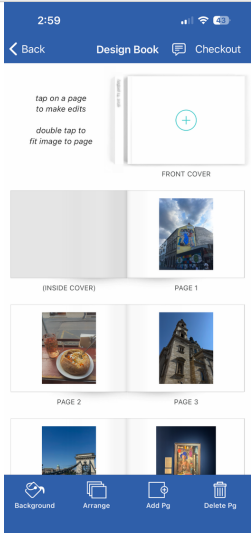
Consolidating to a single edit entry point, and making first-run guidance retrievable, increases editor completion among first-time users — the cohort with no learned model of the interface.

METRIC

Editor-start to checkout-start completion rate. Secondary: back-navigation events per editing session; time-in-editor for first-time versus returning users.

RECOMMENDATION

Keep tap-to-edit as the primary model for page-level changes and demote the bottom bar to book-level actions only (add, delete, arrange). Add a persistent help affordance that re-opens first-run guidance on demand.



Design Book. Tap-to-edit and the bottom tool bar both act on the page.

P2 The return offer is mistimed and aimed at the wrong cost

OBSERVED

A 50%-off-shipping offer for the next order appears at checkout. It is the only return mechanism surfaced anywhere in the observed flow, and it arrives on the same screen as the unexpected \$4.68 charge.

WHY IT IS WEAK

Three reasons. It is measured against the wrong anchor — the first order was free with free shipping, so the customer's reference price is zero, and half-price shipping reads as an increase rather than a reward. It discounts a cost the customer never felt, while leaving untouched the page overage that actually surprised them. And it lands at the point of maximum friction in the flow rather than the point of maximum satisfaction, which is delivery.

CAVEAT

Post-purchase email, push, and account-level offers were not observed in this session and may extend or repeat this offer later.

HYPOTHESIS

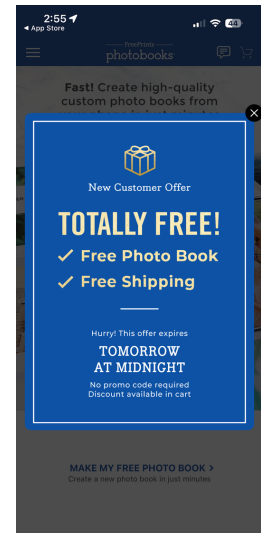
A return offer triggered on delivery confirmation, and framed against the cost the customer actually felt, converts better than a checkout-time shipping discount — because the customer has just handled the product quality that justifies a second order, and because the benefit maps to a cost they remember paying.

METRIC

90-day repeat purchase rate within the free-book acquisition cohort, split by offer variant.

RECOMMENDATION

Move the trigger from checkout to delivery confirmation. A/B the current 50%-off-shipping offer against a waived page overage allowance on the next book — the benefit that directly resolves P0.



The acquisition offer sets the customer's reference price at zero.

Minor — background editor. The Patterns tab has no “None” option. Clearing a pattern requires selecting a color from the adjacent tab, which is not signposted; the expected behavior is that a color would layer beneath the pattern rather than replace it. Low impact, low effort — a “None” swatch at the front of the Patterns row resolves it.

Prepared independently as a first-time customer. Not affiliated with PlanetArt. Pricing figures reflect one observed US order in August 2026 and may vary by region, book size, and promotion.